🗣 DEBATE FRAMEWORK · WATER SAFETY HPE

Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework

A complete framework for using structured argument and debate to deepen water safety knowledge across Year 7–10 — with debate motions, scaffolds, roles, timing guides, and a self-assessment rubric.

Year 7–10 HPE | Cross-curricular: English / VC2E8LY01 · VC2E8LY08 · VC2E9LY01 | VC2HP8P08 · VC2HP8P09 · VC2HP8P10 · VC2HP10P02 · VC2HP10P08

📋 Why Debate in a Water Safety Unit?

The evidence case for structured argument

The deepest form of understanding is being able to argue both sides of a proposition. When students are required to construct a case for a position — and then defend it against challenge — they must engage with the evidence at a level that passive content delivery cannot produce. In a water safety context, this matters particularly because the critical thinking skills developed through structured debate are exactly the skills students need to resist peer pressure, evaluate risk, and advocate for safe behaviour in real situations.

- **Year 7–8:** debate develops VC2HP8P08/126 (analysing health behaviours, evaluating health information) and directly supports the communication product assessment task
- **Year 9–10:** debate develops VC2HP10P02/144/145/148 (data interpretation, social determinants, community service evaluation, policy evaluation) and supports the Policy Brief and Campaign assessment options

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- **Cross-curricular:** persuasive spoken language is a core English Literacy outcome — this framework satisfies both HPE and English objectives simultaneously (VC2E8LY01, VC2E9LY01, VC2E10LY01)

🎯 Learning Outcomes

VC2HP8P10 · VC2HP10P08

Students will…

- Construct an evidence-based argument using real Victorian drowning data
- Distinguish between structural and individual explanations for a health problem
- Anticipate and respond to counter-arguments in real time
- Use health literacy language accurately and persuasively
- Evaluate the strength of evidence behind a claim
- Synthesise unit content into a coherent spoken position

Teachers will see evidence of…

- Depth of factual knowledge (statistics, terminology, frameworks)
- Quality of reasoning (causal links, not just correlations)
- Ability to handle complexity and acknowledge nuance
- Spontaneous application of unit content to novel scenarios
- Communication skills in a formal speaking context
- Peer engagement and active listening during rebuttal

🗓 When to Use This Framework

Best positioned at Lesson 5 (Year 7–8) or Lesson 4–5 (Year 9–10)

Debate works best when students have enough content knowledge to construct a genuine argument — but still enough time to connect the experience to their summative assessment task. A debate in the final lesson of the unit serves consolidation but misses the opportunity to feed into the assessment.

- **Year 7–8:** Run as a class activity in Lesson 5, just before the communication product task. Students who have just debated a proposition are significantly better at producing audience-targeted communication products.
- **Year 9–10:** Run as preparation for the Policy Brief or Campaign task. After debating a motion, students typically produce stronger evidence-cited arguments with more confident counter-argument acknowledgement.

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- **Cross-curricular delivery:** The framework can be delivered as a double period with an English teacher co-present — HPE teacher assesses content; English teacher assesses spoken language.

💬 Debate Motions — Year 7–8

VC2HP8P08 · VC2HP8P10 · VC2HP8P09

How to choose a motion

The best debate motions for this unit are genuinely contestable — there is real evidence on both sides. Avoid motions with obvious right answers. The goal is argument construction, not knowledge recall.

YEAR 7–8 · MOTION 1

"This house believes that swimming ability alone is NOT enough to keep you safe near water."

YEAR 7–8 · MOTION 2

"This house believes that peer pressure is the leading cause of dangerous behaviour near water for young people."

YEAR 7–8 · MOTION 3

"This house believes that every Victorian secondary school student should be required to complete CPR certification before Year 10."

YEAR 7–8 · MOTION 4

"This house believes that rivers and dams are more dangerous than ocean beaches for Victorian teenagers."

YEAR 7–8 · MOTION 5

"This house believes that alcohol near water should be completely banned in Victoria."

YEAR 7–8 · MOTION 6

"This house believes that life-saving skills — not swimming skills — should be the primary focus of school water safety education."

💬 Debate Motions — Year 9–10

VC2HP10P02 · VC2HP10P08 · VC2HP10P09

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 1

"This house believes that the Victorian Government should fund multicultural community swim programs before expanding lifeguard patrols."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 2

"This house believes that the male drowning rate will not significantly improve until masculinity norms around risk-taking are directly challenged in schools."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 3

"This house believes that mandatory pool fencing is a more cost-effective drowning prevention strategy than public awareness campaigns."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 4

"This house believes that Australia's approach to water safety education is superior to the UK's Float to Live model."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 5

"This house believes that structural inequality — not individual behaviour — is the primary driver of drowning disproportionality in Victoria."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 6

"This house believes that Victorian drowning statistics should be disaggregated and publicly reported by demographic group to drive equitable policy responses."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 7

"This house believes that alcohol advertising should be banned at and around Victorian beaches, pools and waterways."

YEAR 9–10 · MOTION 8

"This house believes that Australian beach safety signage has failed if most visitors cannot interpret it, and should be redesigned rather than translated."

💬 Persuasive Discussion Prompts — All Year Levels

When structured debate is too formal — use these instead

For classes where full structured debate is not appropriate (time, ability range, dynamics), these prompts work as Socratic discussion starters or think-pair-share activities. They still require evidence-based reasoning.

ALL YEAR LEVELS

"If you could only teach a group of Year 5 students ONE water safety fact, what would it be — and why that one?"

ALL YEAR LEVELS

"A friend says 'I can swim really well so I don't need to worry about rips.' What's wrong with this argument — and what would you say?"

ALL YEAR LEVELS

"The Victorian Government has $10 million to spend on drowning prevention. What would you spend it on — and what evidence supports your choice?"

ALL YEAR LEVELS

"Should water safety education be compulsory in every year of secondary school, or is it better taught once and done well? Justify your position."

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⏱️ Standard Format — 50-Minute Class Debate

PREPARATION

12 min

Teams prepare, allocate arguments, find evidence

FIRST SPEAKERS

8 min

Affirmative 1 (3min) + Negative 1 (3min) + 2 min crossfire

SECOND SPEAKERS

8 min

Affirmative 2 (3min) + Negative 2 (3min) + 2 min crossfire

REBUTTALS

8 min

Affirmative rebuttal (3min) + Negative rebuttal (3min) + 2 min

ADJUDICATION

14 min

Panel deliberates (5min) + delivers verdict and feedback (9min)

👥 Roles — Debaters

AFFIRMATIVE · ROLES 1–2

First Affirmative

Define the motion. State the team's three arguments. Deliver the first argument with at least one cited statistic. Set the frame for the whole debate.

AFFIRMATIVE · ROLES 3

Second Affirmative

Rebuild the case after the negative attack. Deliver the second and third arguments. Begin to counter-attack the negative's position with evidence.

AFFIRMATIVE · ROLES 4

Affirmative Rebuttal

Identify the most important clash point. Attack the negative's strongest argument. Summarise why the affirmative case is stronger overall. Do NOT introduce new arguments.

NEGATIVE · ROLE 1

First Negative

Accept or challenge the definition. Rebut the affirmative's first argument directly. State the negative team's three arguments. Deliver the first argument.

NEGATIVE · ROLE 2

Second Negative

Rebuild the negative case. Deliver the second and third arguments. Counter-attack the affirmative's two arguments — each with specific evidence.

NEGATIVE · ROLE 3

Negative Rebuttal

Identify the key clash point. Argue why the negative wins it. Summarise the negative's strongest two arguments. Do NOT introduce new arguments.

⚖️ Roles — Adjudicators & Observers

🏛 Adjudication Panel (3 students)

During the debate: take notes under three headings — Matter (arguments and evidence), Manner (confidence and

📋 Observer Roles (remaining students)

Observers are not passive — assign each a specific tracking task:

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clarity), Method (structure and rebuttal quality).

After the debate: reach a majority verdict in 5 minutes, then deliver 2–3 minutes of specific feedback to each team before announcing the winner. Feedback must include one thing each team did well and one specific area to improve.

- **Evidence tracker:** note every statistic cited and whether it was sourced
- **Clash mapper:** track where the two teams directly contradict each other
- **Fallacy spotter:** identify any arguments that rely on emotion rather than evidence
- **Language tracker:** record HPE vocabulary used accurately

📐 Formats for Smaller Groups or Less Time

⚡ Quick Debate (25 min)

2 students per side. First speaker 2 min each. One rebuttal each. Class votes. Teacher facilitates adjudication discussion (no panel). Works well as lesson starter.

💭 Socratic Seminar (40 min)

No sides assigned. 8–12 students in inner circle, rest observe. Teacher poses discussion prompt. Students respond to each other, not the teacher. Focus on building on and challenging each other's reasoning.

🔄 Four Corners (20 min)

Post Strongly Agree / Agree / Disagree / Strongly Disagree in room corners. Read a statement. Students move to their corner and justify their position to a student from a different corner. Fast, physical, high engagement.

✏️ Argument Construction Scaffold

VC2HP8P10 · VC2E8LY01 · VC2E8LY08

How to use the scaffold

Work through each block in order. Each block requires you to answer specific questions — not just write general points. A complete argument has all four blocks. A rebuttal only needs blocks 3 and 4 applied to the opposing argument.

BLOCK 1 — OPENING & CLAIM

State your position clearly. One sentence. No hedging. Your argument is either true or it isn't — commit to it.

"We argue that [state position] because [one-line reason]. This matters because [connection to real Victorian data or lived impact]."

Common mistake: starting with "I think..." — this weakens the claim. State it as fact that you will prove.

BLOCK 2 — EVIDENCE & REASONING

Cite at least one specific piece of evidence. The evidence must be from a named primary source. Then explain WHY this evidence supports your claim — do not assume the connection is obvious.

"According to the Life Saving Victoria 2024–25 Victorian Drowning Report, [statistic]. This shows that [explanation of what the data means]. If [state the implication], then [connect back to the motion]."

A-standard evidence reasoning explains the causal mechanism, not just the correlation. Why does the evidence prove the claim — not just illustrate it?

Key statistics you can cite in this debate:

- 52 Victorian drowning deaths in 2024–25 — below the 2020–21 peak of 64, but 9% above the ten-year average of 48 (LSV)
- Zero deaths at patrolled locations in 2024–25 (LSV)
- 73% of Victorian drowning deaths were male (LSV 2024–25)
- Multicultural communities: 37% of deaths since 2015–16, 185 deaths; 22% of cases had unknown country of birth (LSV 2024–25)
- Non-fatal drownings 60% above the 10-year average in 2024–25 (LSV)
- around 300,000 global drowning deaths annually — 92% in low- and middle-income countries (WHO 2024)
- Four-sided pool fencing reduces child home-pool drowning by ~83% (evidence review)

BLOCK 3 — COUNTER-ARGUMENT & REBUTTAL

Acknowledge the strongest argument on the other side. Then refute it — not by dismissing it, but by explaining why it is outweighed by your evidence, applies in limited circumstances, or rests on a faulty assumption.

"The [negative/affirmative] team may argue that [state their strongest point accurately]. While this is true in [limited context], it does not apply here because [specific reason]. Furthermore, even if this were accepted, it does not outweigh [your evidence] which shows [connection to motion]."

Failure to acknowledge any opposing argument at all is the single most common reason debates are lost at adjudication. It signals shallow thinking, not strength.

BLOCK 4 — SUMMARY & IMPACT

Restate your claim in fresh language. Connect it to real-world consequences — not just logical validity. End with a statement about what would happen if the motion were not accepted.

"In summary, we have shown that [restate claim in different words]. The evidence from [source] demonstrates [key point]. If [opposing position] were accepted, the result would be [specific real-world consequence]. For these reasons, [this house affirms / negates] the motion."

🔄 Rebuttal Scaffold — Responding in Real Time

The AREA Method for spontaneous rebuttal

A
ACKNOWLEDGE
"The [team] claims that…"

R
REFUTE
"However, this fails because…"

E
EVIDENCE
"The LSV data shows that…"

A
AFFIRM
"This strengthens our position because…"

📊 Assessment Rubric — Structured Debate

Criterion	A Excellent	B Proficient	C Developing	D/E Beginning
Evidence quality *VC2HP8P10 / 144*	Cites 2+ primary sources accurately, with full source identification. Data is correctly interpreted and directly connected to the claim.	Cites at least 1 primary source accurately. Connection between evidence and claim is clear but not fully explained.	References general knowledge or unit content without citing a specific source. Connection to claim is implied.	No evidence cited, or evidence is factually incorrect.

Criterion	A Excellent	B Proficient	C Developing	D/E Beginning
Argument structure *VC2E8LY08 / VC2E9LY08*	All four scaffold blocks present and logically connected. Claim → Evidence → Counter → Summary forms a coherent, persuasive whole.	Three of four blocks present. Logical flow is mostly clear with one weak transition.	Argument contains a claim and some evidence but lacks a counter-argument or a clear summary.	Argument is a list of points without connecting reasoning.
Counter-argument *VC2HP8P10 / 144*	Accurately represents the opposing argument, then refutes it with specific evidence. Acknowledges the limits of own position.	Identifies an opposing argument and addresses it, though the refutation is partial or relies on assertion rather than evidence.	Mentions that opposing arguments exist but does not engage with them substantively.	No counter-argument acknowledged.
Health knowledge *VC2HP8P08 / 143*	Uses unit terminology accurately and fluently. Statistics are correct and contextualised. Demonstrates synthesis across multiple unit concepts.	Uses key unit terms mostly accurately. One or two minor factual imprecisions. Shows solid understanding of core content.	Uses some unit terminology but with inconsistencies. One significant factual error or omission.	Limited use of unit content. Significant factual errors present.
Communication *VC2E8LY01 / VC2E9LY01*	Confident, clear delivery. Maintains audience engagement. Responds fluently in crossfire. Does not read directly from notes.	Clear delivery. Occasional reference to notes. Responds to crossfire questions with substance.	Delivery is hesitant but intelligible. Relies heavily on written notes. Crossfire responses are brief.	Delivery is unclear or inaudible. Unable to respond to crossfire without significant prompting.

✅ Student Self-Assessment

After your debate — rate yourself honestly

Use: 4 = Strongly agree · 3 = Mostly agree · 2 = Partly agree · 1 = Not yet

My opening clearly stated my position in one sentence	4	3	2	1
I cited at least one specific statistic with its source	4	3	2	1
I explained WHY my evidence proved my claim (not just stated it)	4	3	2	1
I acknowledged an opposing argument and directly refuted it	4	3	2	1
I used water safety terminology from the unit accurately	4	3	2	1
I listened actively to opposing arguments — not just waited for my turn	4	3	2	1
I responded in crossfire with substance rather than deflection	4	3	2	1

One thing I argued well:

One thing I would do differently next time:

Swim & Water Safety — Structured Debate & Persuasive Discussion Framework · Year 7–10 HPE · Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0

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